Trevor White
@trevorwwhite29

Welcome back for Day 2 of the 12 Days of Madness. A series where I break down different historical indicators of success in the NCAA tournament.

Today's Topic: Size and Dominant Bigs

Stick around to the end to see how this applies to the 2026 field.

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Metrics used include:
-EFFHGT: a measure of Effective Height
-PORPAG: Points Over Replacement Per Adjusted Game (for identifying dominant bigs)

Both "compiled with sacred data and secret formulas" at barttorvik.com.

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Interestingly, EFFHGT among tournament teams has grown consistently over time.

The number of dominant big men has not.

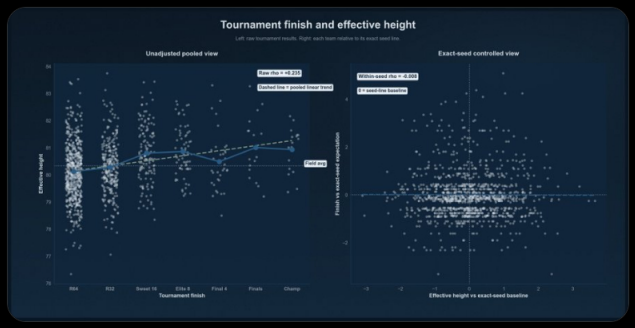


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When controlling for seed, plotting EFFHGT over time illustrates an irrelevant predictive effect on a team's overperformance in March.

In fact, teams with outlier EFFHGT (in both directions) seem to run into trouble early.



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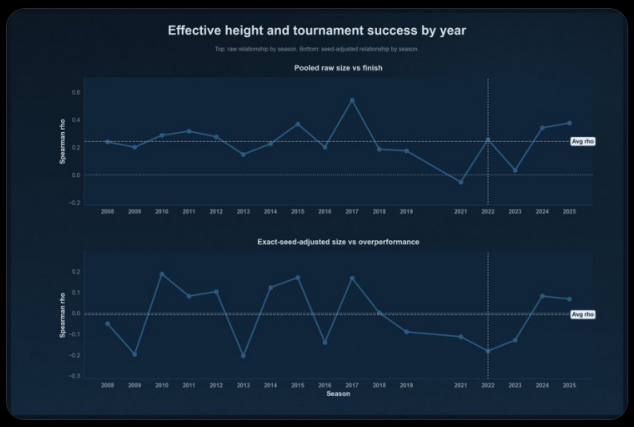
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The past two years have been slightly favorable towards big teams. But the 5 years prior were not.

Ultimately, nothing very meaningful here.



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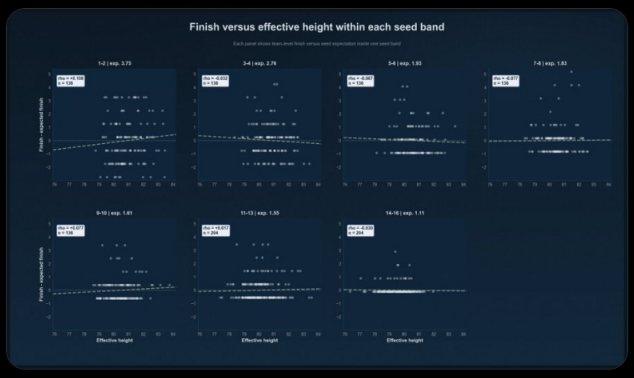
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The relationship between height and success varies slightly across seed groups.

For 1-2 and 9-10 seeds, it seems to be a positive.

For 3-6, it is the opposite.

For the rest, we see no trend.

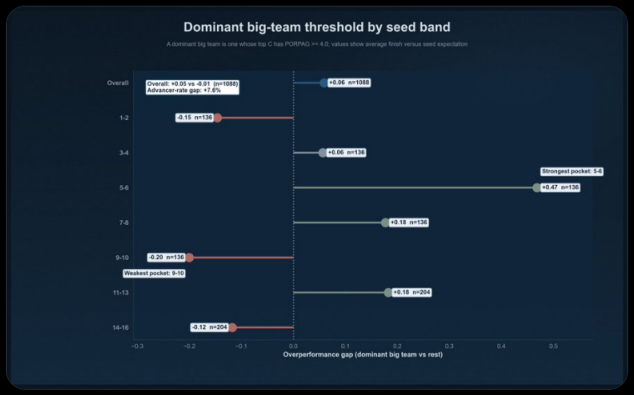


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Despite 1-2 and 9-10 seeds benefitting from height, those with dominant bigs have not seen the same benefit. Suggesting that perhaps backcourt length is more crucial.

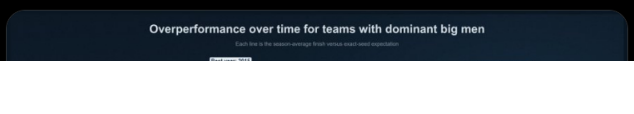
Seeds 3-8 and 11-13 seem to thrive with a dominant big.

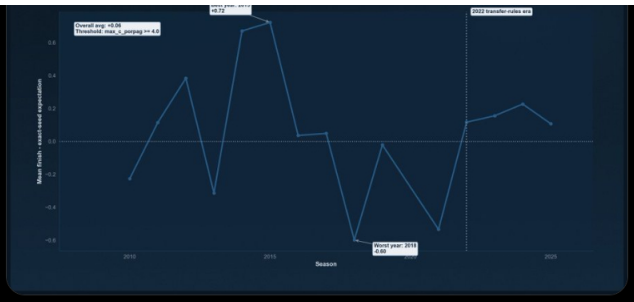


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The benefit of a dominant big man has been quite volatile over time, so it's hard to say whether a dominant big matters more in March.





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Florida proved last year that height can win in March, and they're even bigger this year. EFFHGT showed to help 1-2 seeds so this looks good for them UI and UM.

The low-middle seeds may not see the same benefit.



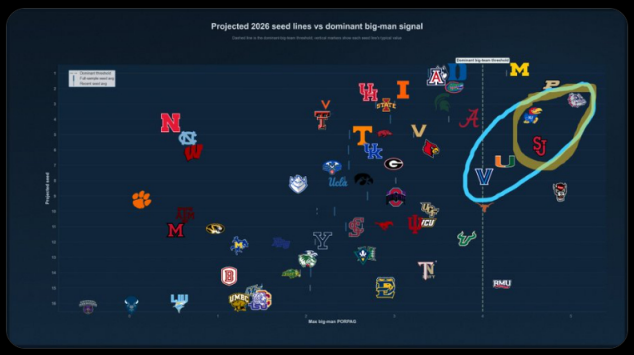
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Though 1-2 seeds don't reap the benefits of bigs typically, Michigan and Purdue aren't overly dependent on theirs.

While the circled teams are in the seed range where bigs may mean more, providing security vs lower seeds.

Also, RMU's DeSean Goode is 36-60 on 3's this year???



1 10

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What could've been for UNC with Caleb Wilson though... smh

1 11

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I mentioned that 1-2 and 9-10 seeds may benefit from backcourt length. This looks favorable for Duke.

And while Santa Clara isn't a 9-10 seed, I think they should be, and that length could be an interesting matchup, especially if they somehow got Georgia.





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